My Game Design Document

Sneak Peek

A first look at the game we're all building this semester

VIDEO GAME CREATION

Name (optional - this is just a preview to keep):

This Semester, We're All Making...

A top-down arcade shooter, in the tradition of classics like Space Invaders and Galaga: waves of enemies descend from above - move, dodge, and shoot your way through before they reach you.

This is exactly how a real game studio kicks off a project - a short, exciting "high concept" pitch, before anyone writes a full design or a line of code. We picked this idea on purpose: it needs almost no art or animation to start, but it has room to grow into something genuinely impressive by the end of the semester.

Here's the twist: everyone in class builds this same game. That's not a limit on your creativity - it's the opposite. Because nobody has to invent the game from scratch, you get to spend the semester getting really good at your engine and your code, while still making the game feel like yours through your own art, sound, and extra touches. Think of it like a gymnast's compulsory routine - same core moves for everyone, but every performance still looks different. Semester 2 is where you get a fully free-form, entirely-your-own game to design.

Full details - exactly how it works, level by level - get revealed a piece at a time as we build it together, lesson by lesson. Today, this is all you need to know: what it is, and that you're going to build it.

How This Class Is Leveled

Every project in this class - starting with the very first one next week - gets judged against three levels, not just "done" or "not done":

Level	Think of it as...	What it means
Level 1 - Minimal	MVP	The smallest working version - enough to understand the idea and move on. A complete, legitimate finish.
Level 2 - Complete	Internal Alpha/Beta	All expected features present and working end-to-end. Art/polish/balance may still be missing.
Level 3 - Refined	Ready to Publish	Feature-complete, tested, and polished enough to comfortably share outside of class.

Level 1 is always a real, complete finish - not a rough draft. Levels 2 and 3 are for anyone with time and curiosity to push further.

Where This Is Going

This is the actual 30-lesson roadmap for the whole class, start to finish. It's a lot to take in on day one - the point isn't to memorize it, just to see the shape of the year and get excited about where it leads.

Lessons	Class Focus	Class Milestone
1	Orientation: internet safety, game dev overview, platform selection	Engine installed & first project opened
2-6	Programming foundations: variables, events, loops, conditionals, input	First moving, controllable character
7-11	Core mechanics: collision, scoring, win/lose states, simple UI	Small playable prototype
12-15	Game feel & polish: audio, basic animation, level structure	Semester 1 capstone: complete Mini-Game
16-20	Intermediate systems: state machines, enemy/AI behavior, physics	Prototype with opponents/obstacles
21-25	Expanding scope: menus, save data, multiple levels, juice/polish	Feature-complete draft of capstone game
26-28	Playtesting, bug-fixing, presentation prep	Playtested, stable build
29-30	Finalize, package, and export shareable copies	Shareable build ready for CoOp Expo

The Five Disciplines of Game Development

Every game - including the one you'll be building - touches all five of these, even on a small student project. Programming is our main focus in class, but the other four matter too, and your real Game Design Document will have space for notes on each.

- **Design:** Deciding what the game is and how it plays - the rules, the goals, the feel.
- **Programming:** Making the rules and mechanics actually work in code (our main focus this year).
- **Visual Art:** Characters, environments, and UI - what the player sees.
- **Audio:** Music and sound effects - what the player hears.
- **Production:** Planning, scoping, and finishing a project - relevant all year, critical before the Expo.

Coming Up in Lesson 2

Next class, you'll pick the engine or platform you want to build in, get your own copy of the real Game Design Document, and write your very first working program: a little character that reacts to a key press. That character is where our game starts.

Between now and then, it's worth thinking about:

- What should our ship or character look like? (Sketch it if you want - default and placeholder art are always fine too.)
- What would you name this game? We'll pick an official title together once we've actually started building it - real studios do this too.
- Which engine sounds most interesting to you for building it? (Ask your instructor if you're not sure - there's no wrong choice.)

See you next class - let's build it!